Question ID: cac82f9b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Medium

Question

Biologist Natacha Bodenhausen and colleagues analyzed the naturally occurring bacterial communities associated with leaves and roots of wild *Arabidopsis thaliana*, a small flowering plant. The researchers found many of the same bacterial genera in both the plants' leaves and roots. To explain this, the researchers pointed to the general proximity of *A. thaliana* leaves to the ground and noted that rain splashing off soil could bring soil-based bacteria into contact with the leaves. Alternatively, the researchers noted that wind, which may be a source of bacteria in the aboveground portion of plants, could also bring bacteria to the soil and roots. Either explanation suggests that ______

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

A. bacteria carried by wind are typically less beneficial to *A. thaliana* than soil-based bacteria are.

B. some bacteria in *A. thaliana* leaves and roots may share a common source.

C. many bacteria in *A. thaliana* leaves may have been deposited by means other than rain.

D. *A. thaliana* leaves and roots are especially vulnerable to harmful bacteria.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Both explanations suggest that the bacteria come from the same place: either they come from the ground and make their way to the leaves, or they come from above the ground and make their way to the roots.

Choice A is incorrect. This inference isn't supported. The text never discusses any benefits of any kind of bacteria. Choice C is incorrect. This conflicts with the text. One of the theories is that the bacteria in the leaves were deposited by rain splashing off soil. Choice D is incorrect. This inference isn't supported. The text only discusses "naturally occurring" bacteria. It never mentions either the harms or benefits of these bacteria.